

like he had paid all her bills, but she never really gave it much thought. But then in the early part of her senior year Andrea's father died suddenly of a heart attack. Her mother was devastated by her loss and went into a prolonged state of depression. Andrea withdrew from school for the semester and then returned to finish her degree.

In the past, her father had always given her money for the incidentals she needed just before she left for school. Since her father was gone, Andrea approached her mother.

"Mom, I'll need some money for books and dorm fees," she said.

"Dad always handled the finances, honey. I don't know what you need. Why don't you take my credit card and get whatever is necessary. We'll work it out when you come home next time. Maybe Daddy's insurance will be settled by that time, and I'll know what we have."

Andrea's mom then handed her two credit cards: one for buying gas for her car and the other for general expenses. Although Andrea had never owned a card of her own, she had often used her mother's card to fill the family car or run errands for her mom. The cards had only her mother's initials and last name on them. Because Andrea had the same initials as her mother, the merchants never questioned her signature.

Back at school Andrea called home regularly to see how her mom was doing. She was still in a state of semi-shock, and Andrea called her almost every day. When the first month's phone bill came for Andrea's cell phone, she had gone over her minutes, so she paid the bill with the card her mother had given her.

Andrea needed some clothes for school and normally would have called and asked her dad for some money. Usually he sent her a check, and she would buy a pair of jeans and a blouse or two. Since she knew her mother was in no shape to answer questions, she decided to use the card this time. By the time she finished the shopping trip she had charged over several hundred dollars' worth of new clothes and had also charged a watch for Bill.